

E-Mails: When and How to Write an E-Mail

Technical Writing & Presentation Skills

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What is Email?



Definition

Email (electronic mail) is a digital communication method that enables sending and receiving messages, files, and images between users over computer networks or the internet.



Contents

An email can contain text, documents, images, links, and other attachments.



Use

Email is commonly used as a formal communication channel in universities and workplaces.



Why Email Matters

Record

Email creates written records, which help with accountability and can be used for future reference.

Reach

Email creates written records, which help with accountability and can be used for future reference.

Professionalism

Email is a professional standard for sending formal requests, reports and applications.



When to Write an Email

Use email when communication must be formal, tracked, or attached to a record.

- Contact professors or managers
- Submit assignments or reports
- Apply for internships/jobs



When to Use Email vs. Chat or Calls

Scenario	Preferred Tool
Formal requests (extensions, approvals)	Email
Large attachments (>5MB) or records	Email
Asynchronous updates (weekly report)	Email
Urgent incident	Call/Chat, then Email summary



Rule of thumb: Email for records and decisions; chat for speed and coordination. If the reply is needed in under 1 hour, choose chat or a call—then document outcomes via email.

When Software Engineers Use Email



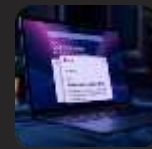
Project Status

Summarize progress, next steps, and blockers.



Bug Reports

Include steps to reproduce, severity, and attachments.



Scheduling

Propose times, include agenda and meeting link.



Docs & Client Notes

Share specs, docs, or client communications with versioned attachments.

Basic Structure of a Professional Email

1

Subject Line

Short, specific summary of purpose.

2

Greeting

Polite salutation (use names/titles).

3

Introduction

One sentence: state the purpose and context of the email.

4

Main Message

Clear points, short paragraphs, actionable items.

5

Closing & Signature

Polite sign-off and contact details.



Vase subject
Line, fem.

Writing an Effective Subject Line

Keep it short, clear, and outcome-oriented. Include context like project name, type, and date when relevant.

- Good

Project Alpha — Database Module Completed (Mar 10)

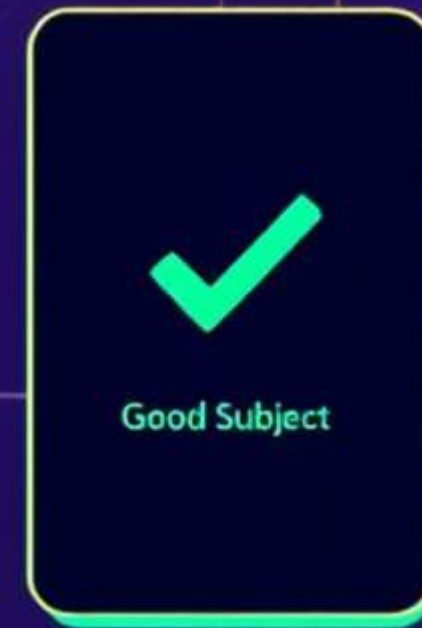
- Bad

Hello / Important Message

Crafting Killer Subject Lines

- Good: "Feedback Needed: API Endpoint Proposal — Due Fri 5pm"
- Bad: "Hey" or "Question"
- Tips: use action verbs (Review, Confirm), include deadline, keep it scannable (≤50 chars ideal)

Analogy: Treat your subject like a git commit message — precise and searchable.



Body: Tone & Structure

Write concise paragraphs focused on a single topic. Use bullets for lists and explicit action items. Be polite, neutral, and professional.

Example

"I am writing to inform you that the project documentation has been completed. Please review the attached file and provide feedback by Friday."

Action Items

State requests clearly: who, what, when.



Attachments & Tech Best Practices



- Name files clearly: "Zohaib_Resume_v2.pdf"
- Prefer links to repos (GitHub) rather than raw code attachments
- Keep attachments <10MB; compress or share via cloud if larger
- Include a short README or summary with code attachments

❏ Never "email your code" unzipped—use a repo link with commit reference and README for reproducibility.

Email Etiquette & Common Mistakes

- Always include a subject line
- Use a polite greeting and sign-off
- Proofread for grammar and attachments
- Avoid ALL CAPS and slang
- Keep messages focused and scannable

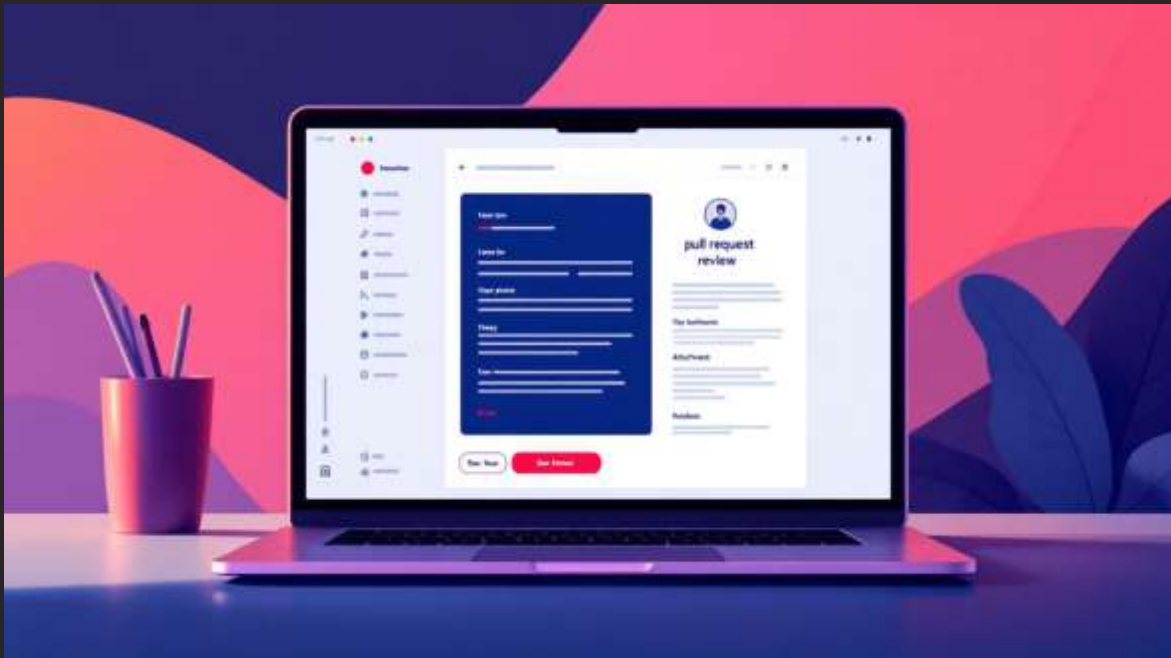
Common Errors

- Missing attachments
- Unclear requests
- Overly long emails
- Informal tone



Real SE Example: Pull Request Review Request

Subject: Review Request: Pull Request #45 - Authentication Module



Dear Prof. Khan,

I'm seeking your feedback on my sprint deliverable. Key changes:

- Implemented JWT auth — attached sequence diagram
- Fixed SQL injection vulnerability
- Unit tests: 95% coverage

Could you review by Wednesday? I can demo the flow in 10 minutes if needed.

Best, Jhon Dravis —Junior Software Engineering,
jhon@example.com

Conclusion & Quick Checklist

1 Subject

Make it specific and short.

2. Body

One topic per email; use bullets; state actions and deadlines.

3. Proof & Attach

Check grammar, recipients, and attachments before sending.

Mastering professional email writing improves clarity, builds credibility, and is an essential skill for every software engineer.

